



Solid start: This season, Vyshak (second from left) has taken five wickets in his first two games for Punjab Kings, already one more than his total tally in each of the previous two editions. R. RAGU

came and said that no matter what, I had to keep sticking to the same thing. As a bowler, if somebody gives you that much confidence, you don't require much when you are playing at the highest level, right?"

Vyshak ended up conceding only five runs in each of his first two overs. Shreyas' call held up, the damage was done, and PBKS went on to win by 11 runs. "As a fast bowler, if you're playing at the highest level, you've got to be ready for all challenges. So, we make sure we are prepared. Say there's a lot of dew in Ahmedabad and then you get a wet ball; you can't complain, right? (For such situations) we make sure we practise enough to bowl those yorkers — doesn't matter if it is wet or not. When the captain comes and gives you the ball, you can't be saying, 'S**t, I've not

practiced bowling wide yorkers!' You always keep yourself up to the challenge."

Into his second year with the Kings, it's almost like Vyshak never left home in the first place. He appears more assured, aware that this phase is about refinement. "The first stint with Royal Challengers Bengaluru (2023-2024) helped me grow as a cricketer. I am where I am because of that, so I am very grateful. In the IPL, you represent a certain franchise, and that is where you give your heart and soul. (At PBKS), nothing much has changed. It's just that I have grown in confidence as a fast bowler. I would say I'm a better and more confident bowler than how I was in the first year... I want to play and win all the games, but the IPL is such a format that you never know what is going to happen."

These weren't mere rehearsed lines. Vyshak's words could be substantiated with numbers.

Although he made an immediate impact at RCB, registering career-best figures of 3/20 on his tournament debut against Delhi

Capitals, he could only take 10 more wickets in as many games during his two-year stint with the Red and Gold brigade. His economy rate was 10.25 across that span.

Even last year, except for the game against GT, his returns at PBKS were largely tepid. But the franchise, having got a glimpse of what he was capable of in that first game, decided to retain him.

In 2026, Vyshak has repaid that faith as a vital component of the pace battery. In his first two games, he has taken five wickets — already one more than his total tally in each of the previous two editions.

"I have had the same approach this year. I want to make sure I put in some effort and contribute to the team's victory. I think that is more important than just looking at the number of wickets. I don't look at the numbers. Yes, wickets are coming, and that is good, and I'm very happy. I hope I can continue getting those wickets. But as long as we are doing the processes right, we will win games. I think that is more important, and that is what I am